Westbrook School Committee

~ Finance Committee Meeting ~

Date: Wednesday, March 18, 2026
Time: 5:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1174915735
Packet: No agenda was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org, 2026-10-24).

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *The full committee sat as the committee of the whole for this FY27 cost-center budget review session; no votes were taken. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Unofficial summary. *This is produced by Westbrook Currents, an independent site — not the City of Westbrook — and may contain mistakes. For the official record, see the City's approved minutes and the meeting video.*

Music & Performing Arts Center

Music Department Budget Review [11:04]

Discussion Summary

Director of Music Suzanne Prue reported a strong year (31 students to District Honors ensembles, 11 to All-State, 16 to the District Honors Jazz Festival), but flagged a roughly 25% ($2,000) cut to the middle school's per-pupil supplies line, driven by a smaller participating student count. She said the middle school has already exhausted its instrument-repair budget this year and is borrowing from the high school's repair line, and that the cut would meaningfully affect consumables like reeds and mouthpieces.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items

None.

Westbrook Performing Arts Center: Self-Sustaining, Zero General Fund Impact

[23:54]

Discussion Summary

Jamie Grant reported the Center remains fully self-sustaining: FY25 revenue of $193,666 against $131,561 in expenses, a $62,105 surplus, confirmed by Dr. Mazjanis as having zero effect on the general fund. This year's surplus plus a Warren Memorial Foundation grant funded a $92,000 lighting upgrade. Member Andrea Mancuso noted this fulfills the promise made when the Center was built roughly sixteen years ago that it would never cost taxpayers.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items
None.

Facilities & Maintenance

Energy Savings Confirmed in the Budget; Waste Removal, HVAC & High School Repairs [35:09]

Discussion Summary
Director of Facilities Tony Lombardo walked through utilities and repair lines for each building. Member Andrea Mancuso confirmed with Dr. Mazjanis the budget-level energy savings: solar generation saves a projected $302,300 against $223,830 in bonding debt service (net $66,170), and the Siemens efficiency project saves $279,444 against $256,453 in debt service (net $22,987) — roughly $89,000 in real FY27 savings combined, expected to grow as energy prices rise.

Waste removal costs rose sharply after the district learned it was no longer covered under a municipal joint-vendor arrangement with the City (no written agreement was ever found); Lombardo negotiated a rate the vendor has verbally committed to hold for several years. Middle school HVAC concerns include a failing air handler and a two-year-old chiller component the vendor won't honor under warranty. High school repairs include a $15,000 federal tree-replacement grant requiring a match, Compass program relocation costs, and roof/sidewalk safety work; members asked whether some of these could be capital-improvement eligible rather than absorbed into the operating repair budget.

Key Decisions
✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items
None.

Point / Counterpoint

> *“It feels like we're robbing Peter to pay Paul. We are a department of the city and we are paying the city to do work...it's hard to look at $121,000 and think about the teaching position that could be filling that.”*

— Board Member (on a $121,000 annual city charge for athletic-field maintenance) [01:39:23]

Transportation

New Positions Requested; BusRight Parent-Tracking Rollout [01:54:48]

Discussion Summary
Director of Transportation Melissa Foy requested two new positions: a van driver (cut last year, which she said has required her to personally drive long out-of-district routes) and a bus aide for a specific out-of-district placement. She flagged rising bus replacement costs (now about $172,000, up from under $100,000 six years ago). She also voiced genuine safety concern about the upcoming March 27 rollout of real-time bus tracking for

parents, worried it could lead some parents to let children wait unsupervised or run toward an arriving bus, and said translation services will ensure rollout communications reach families in their home languages.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items

None.

Technology

New Network Support Specialist Requested, Citing Cybersecurity Risk [02:45:34]

Discussion Summary

IT staff member Barbara Morgan opened with a pointed cybersecurity framing: 52% of U.S. school districts experienced a cybersecurity incident in a recent study (up from 31% two years prior), citing a recent nearby Portland Public Schools data exposure affecting over 33,000 people. She argued the district's network currently depends on a single administrator, a “single point of failure,” and requested a new Network Support Specialist position (about $78,000) so routine connectivity support no longer pulls the administrator away from security work; the district already effectively spends about $10,000 annually on an after-hours support stipend this position would replace.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items

None.

Art & Human Resources

Art Department: Two Replacement Pottery Wheels Requested [03:38:19]

Discussion Summary

The sole new Art Department request is two replacement pottery wheels: upper-level ceramics enrollment has grown from 3 students two years ago to 27 this year, but two of the classroom's six wheels (purchased in the late 1980s) are increasingly unreliable and raise safety concerns. The department also highlighted 2026 Maine Art Education Association recognition for two of its teachers, previously reported at the March 11 State of the Schools presentation.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items

None.

Human Resources: Smallest Budget, Foundational Role [03:54:13]

Discussion Summary

HR Director Martha Sumner described a department of two (herself and a full-time HR generalist, added only two and a half years ago) supporting 506 employees and three collective bargaining agreements. She noted a past pipe leak damaged some HR and Finance paper records, motivating an ongoing digitization push. Asked whether recent market-rate salary adjustments have affected staff retention, Sumner said she hasn't seen pay-driven resignations this year; Dr. Lancia said he's preparing data that appears to show a positive retention effect from the adjustments.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was transcribed with AI-assisted speech-to-text and speaker identification. This process cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com